visible style of prayer to distinguish themselves from those who follow the Hanafi school of jurisprudence.[79] Such visible demarcations of their faith further separated the Ahl-e-Hadith from other Muslims and marked them as an elitist group with a sense of 'moral superiority.'[80] This left them with a relatively small following in pre-Partition British India, which remained the case in Pakistan and India post-Partition.

The Ahl-e-Hadith movement has made gradual progress in Pakistan since Partition. By the end of the 1980s they were a small, but potent, force particularly in Punjab and the NWFP.[81] In part, this owed to state patronage. Like the Deobandis, the Ahl-e-Hadith benefited from funding for madaris during the 1980s. Saudi support played a prominent role in the movement's growth as well. In the 1920s, the Ahl-e-Hadith began developing international connections with Salafis and Wahhabis in what became Saudi Arabia.[82] Ahl-e-Hadith ties to the religious establishment there have grown stronger since the 1960s. In later years, alumni of Medina University in Saudi Arabia advanced the cause of Salafism as they returned to Pakistan.[83] The Ahl-e-Hadith also gained popularity as a result of the many Pakistanis working in the Gulf region who returned home with Salafi beliefs.[84] These connections to Saudi Arabia were reinforced when thousands of Arabs came to Pakistan to support the Afghan resistance against the Soviets. As described above, Saudi money had been pouring into Pakistan since the early 1980s. When the Jamaat-e Islami supported Iraq during the Gulf War in 1991 the Kingdom shifted the Saudi patronage it had been receiving to the Ahl-e-Hadith, channelling millions of dollars to the movement in Pakistan.[85]

While the number of Ahl-e-Hadith madaris remains miniscule relative to those affiliated with the Deobandi sect, they nonetheless increased from 134 in 1988 to 310 in 2000.[86] They have continued to grow since then. According to the Pakistani government, there were 34,000 students studying in Ahl-e-Hadith madrasas in 2006 compared with 18,800 in 1996.[87] This is almost a 100 per cent increase over ten years. The Ahl-e-Hadith's approach to education is partly responsible for the movement's growth in popularity. Ahl-e-Hadith madaris merge Islamic education with modern curricula, including Pakistan studies, English, mathematics and science. Adherents believe there is no harm in teaching these subjects provided students do not adopt Western culture. This is a markedly